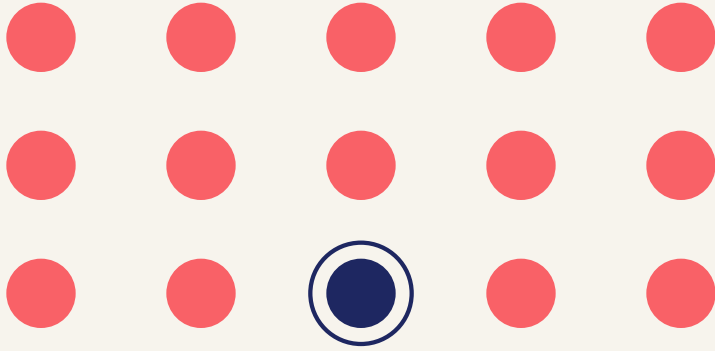




THE COLLABORATION REFLEX

*Why the “right” answer to conflict
is usually wrong*



FORTY-FIVE TRUE STORIES FROM REAL WORKPLACES

YASAS SRI WICKRAMASINGHE, PhD

the collaboration reflex

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*Why the “Right” Answer to Conflict
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Forty-five true stories from real workplaces

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The stories in this book are real. All names are invented, and some identifying details have been altered to protect the people involved. Any resemblance of an invented name to a real person is coincidental.

This book offers general guidance on workplace communication and conflict. It is not legal, psychological or HR advice for any specific situation.

A NOTE ON THE STORIES

Every conflict described in this book really happened. The stories were collected through an anonymous exercise I run in my postgraduate project management classes, where students — most of them working professionals — write about a real conflict they lived through, and then analyse a classmate's story without knowing whose it is.

I have changed every name. I have also softened a few identifying details: an industry here, a city there. What I have not changed is what people did, what they said, and how things ended. Where I quote someone directly, the words are theirs, lightly edited for clarity.

I am grateful to every person who trusted a blank page with one of the worst weeks of their working life. This book exists because they were honest.

— *Yasas*

*For my students, who wrote down the stories
most people only tell in the car park after work.*

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INTRODUCTION

The Day I Collected Forty-Five Fights

IN A PROJECT management class I was teaching, I tried something different. Instead of opening the conflict management week with a lecture, I asked my students to write about a real conflict they had lived through. Not a case study. Not a hypothetical about "Company X." A real one, with real stakes, told anonymously.

My students were not fresh graduates. Most were working professionals in their late twenties, thirties and forties: analysts, auditors, sales reps, warehouse supervisors, developers, coordinators, team leaders. People who had been in rooms where voices were raised, and in rooms where the more dangerous thing happened — voices went quiet.

Forty-five stories came back.

Then I did the second part of the experiment. Each story was handed, still anonymous, to a different student, who had to analyse it cold: What was the real cause? Who stood to lose what? How was it actually handled, and how should it have been handled? It is one thing to judge your own conflict. It is another to have a stranger judge it for you.

When I sat down to read the full set, I expected the usual classroom fare — group assignment squabbles, a missed deadline or two. What I got was closer to a documentary about working life.

There was an internal auditor whose CEO called his findings "false allegations" to his face. A receptionist publicly accused of losing messages she had faithfully passed on. A team leader who quietly deleted the staff group chat rather than answer the questions in it. Two salespeople fighting over one factory client while the confused customer froze the deal. A construction coordinator blamed for a delay she had warned about in writing, two days earlier. A student whose family threatened to cut her off if she left her degree. Two couples sharing a flat, at war over rent transfers and unwashed dishes.

And underneath the variety, patterns. Strong ones. The same handful of mistakes appearing in a bank, a warehouse, a kitchen and a living room. The same small habits — a shared tracker, a written agreement, a private conversation before a public one — rescuing situations that looked completely different on the surface.

This book is what I learned from reading those forty-five stories, and from the forty analyses my students wrote about each other. It is organised around the patterns, not the classroom. You do not need to care about project management as a discipline to use it. You just need to work with other human beings.

What this book is, and what it is not

Let me be straight with you about the evidence. Forty-five stories is not a scientific sample. The stories were self-reported, which means everyone is, to some degree, the hero of their own version. People knew a teacher would read what they wrote, so some endings are probably tidier on paper than they were in life. Where I give you numbers — and I will, because some of them surprised me — treat them as patterns worth testing in your own workplace, not laws of nature.

What makes this collection valuable is not statistical power. It is honesty and range. Anonymity did something remarkable: people wrote things they would never say in a meeting. One team leader

admitted, in writing, that he had stopped caring whether his staff were happy as long as the sales numbers held. A student described a conflict as fully resolved and then, two sentences later, confessed it "still feels like an unresolved emotional issue for me." You do not get sentences like that in an employee survey.

Alongside the stories, I will give you the theory — but only where it earns its place. There are four frameworks in this book, and each one exists because the stories kept bumping into it: a map of the five ways humans handle a clash, an old and underrated distinction between what people demand and what they actually need, a simple discipline for planning communication before it fails, and a way of measuring whether a conflict is truly over. That is the whole theoretical load. I promise not to bury you in models.

The finding that made me write this book

Here is the one that got me.

After my students wrote their own stories, remember, they each analysed someone else's. One question asked: which approach should have been used to handle this conflict? There are five classic options, which you will meet properly in Chapter 2 — competing, collaborating, compromising, avoiding, accommodating.

Three quarters of them gave the same answer: collaborating. Work together. Find the win-win. Almost regardless of the situation. A boss violating written company policy? Collaborate. A finance department with zero incentive to bend? Collaborate. A dispute already settled sensibly by splitting the difference? Should have collaborated.

Not one student, in forty analyses, recommended standing firm and competing. Only one recommended walking away.

These were experienced professionals, and they had just read stories in which forcing and avoiding did most of the damage — so their instinct wasn't crazy. But an answer that fits every question has stopped being an answer. Somewhere along the way, "collaborate"

has become what "synergy" was in the nineties: the word we say to sound wise, whether or not it fits the moment. One of the jobs of this book is to give you back the full menu — including the unfashionable options, and the courage to use them when they fit.

*An answer that fits every question has
stopped being an answer.*

How to read this book

Chapters 1 and 2 set the stage: why conflict is a normal output of working together, and the five moves people make when it arrives. Chapters 3 through 6 walk through what actually happened in the stories — the quiet failures of avoiding, the expensive victories of forcing, the collaboration reflex, and the difference between a conflict that is resolved and one that is merely closed. Chapters 7 through 9 turn to the skills that changed outcomes: finding the argument under the argument, keeping receipts, and treating communication as a system rather than a talent. Chapter 10 collects it all into eight habits you can start using on Monday.



FIGURE 6 · Positions and interests (after Fisher & Ury)

Every chapter ends with take-home messages. They are short on purpose. If you remember nothing else, remember those.

One last thing before we start. When I read the forty-five stories for the first time, I kept a tally of how they ended. Twenty-four ended well — problem solved, relationship intact. Six ended with the problem solved and the relationship quietly broken. At least four never really ended at all. The gap between those groups was almost never intelligence, seniority or even goodwill.

It was usually one conversation, held too late, or never held at all.

1

CHAPTER 1

Why Good Projects Breed Conflict

ONE OF THE STORIES IN MY COLLECTION came from a planner at a manufacturing company — I'll call her Priya. Her job was to look at customer demand and make sure the factory had the materials to meet it. One week, her inventory report showed that a critical raw material would run out within days, putting several customer orders at risk.

Here is the thing: nobody in this story was lazy, stupid or malicious. Priya had flagged rising demand weeks earlier and recommended ordering early. Procurement had delayed the purchase — deliberately, because they believed demand would drop and they are measured on not sitting on excess stock. Production refused to reshuffle the schedule, because they are measured on efficiency and had already committed the line. Sales was furious with everyone, because they are measured on keeping delivery promises to customers.

The weekly review meeting turned tense. Every department defended its decision, and every department was right — by its own scoreboard.

That is the first thing I want you to take from this book, because it changes how you feel when conflict arrives: most workplace conflict is not a malfunction. It is the natural output of a system that asks

people with different goals, different calendars and different scoreboards to share one deadline. If you design an organisation where procurement is rewarded for holding less stock and sales is rewarded for promising more, you have designed that Tuesday meeting. The conflict was built in months before anyone raised a voice.

Project management researchers have known this for decades. In the 1970s, Hans Thamhain and David Wilemon studied where conflict actually erupts across the life of projects, and the answer was mundane: schedules first, then priorities, then resources and technical disagreements. Personality clashes — the thing we usually blame — sat far down the list. My forty-five stories agreed almost embarrassingly well. Deadlines and delays were the single most common trigger. Whose goal wins came second. Genuine personality conflict, the kind where two people simply cannot share oxygen, was rare.

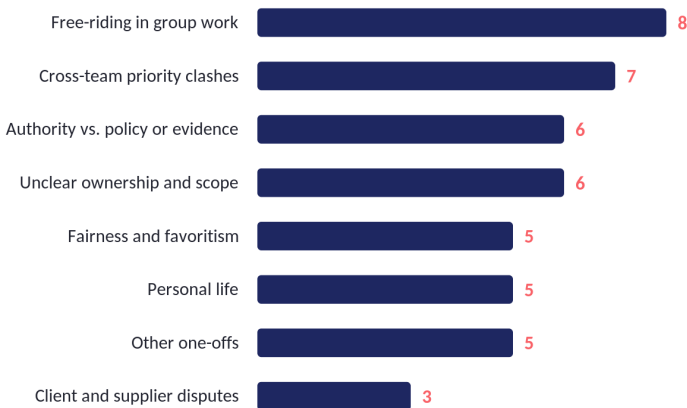


FIGURE 1 · What triggered the forty-five conflicts

There is a second classic idea worth thirty seconds of your time. In 1965, the psychologist Bruce Tuckman described how teams develop through phases he called forming, storming, norming and performing. The detail everyone forgets is that storming — the phase

of friction, testing and pushback — is not a failure state. It is a stage. Teams that never storm often haven't become teams yet; they are just polite strangers sharing a document. Several of my students' stories were, in hindsight, teams meeting their storming phase and mistaking it for the end of the world.

Two kinds of conflict

If conflict is a normal output, does that mean all conflict is fine? No. And the stories drew the line between good and bad conflict more sharply than any textbook I have taught from.

Go back to Priya's factory. That meeting was uncomfortable — people defending turf, blame circling the table. But then the operations manager did something small and important: he stopped the search for a villain and restarted the meeting around a question. Given where we are, what can we actually do? The team pulled up the updated forecasts, checked supplier lead times, looked at substitute materials. They placed an urgent order, re-sequenced production around what was available, and called the affected customers early with honest revised dates.

Then — and this is the part I make my students repeat — they changed the system that had produced the collision. More frequent forecast reviews. Earlier cross-department alerts on high-risk materials. Shared visibility of inventory risk, so the next shortage would be everyone's problem while it was still small.

Priya's conclusion in her written story was that the conflict, handled openly, left the company running better than before. Researchers call this functional conflict: friction that surfaces real information and forces a better design. It is not just tolerable. It is valuable. Some of the most useful facts in an organisation — this deadline is impossible, this rule contradicts that rule, this customer is about to walk — only ever surface as conflict.

Now the other kind. A supervisor in my collection — call him Marcus — had a team member who kept falling asleep at his desk. Deadlines slipped; quality dropped. Marcus did what many decent managers do: he had a quiet word, privately, hoping to fix it without drama. The employee promised to improve, and did, for a while. Then the pattern returned, and Marcus reached for the formal machinery: a performance improvement plan.

The employee read the document not as a second chance but as the first step of being managed out. He resigned before the plan finished. Task closed, in a sense — the sleeping stopped, because the desk was empty. But the team lost a person, his knowledge and a measure of its trust in management, and Marcus never got to find out what the sleeping was about. Dysfunctional conflict does the opposite of functional conflict: it destroys information. Everyone learns to reveal less next time.

The uncomfortable insight from my forty-five stories is that the same conflict can go either way, and the fork in the road usually appears early — long before anyone is shouting. The factory meeting could easily have ended in a memo war. The sleeping employee might have been rescued by a different second conversation. What separates the two paths is rarely the size of the problem. It is how quickly the people involved switch from who caused this to what do we do — and whether anyone thinks to repair the system, not just the incident.

Why this matters to you

If you manage projects, or people, or simply work alongside other humans, this chapter's reframe buys you two practical advantages.

First, it changes your emotional response. If you believe conflict means something has gone wrong, every disagreement arrives as a small emergency, and people who fear emergencies hide them. If you believe conflict is a normal output of shared deadlines and different scoreboards, you can meet it with curiosity instead of dread. The

question stops being who do I blame and becomes what is this friction trying to tell me?

Second, it points your prevention effort at the right target. You cannot hire your way out of conflict, because the causes are structural: schedules, priorities, resources, unclear ownership. But structures can be redesigned. Almost every prevention idea my students proposed — and Chapter 10 collects the best of them — is a small structural fix: make the work visible, write the agreement down, review progress before the deadline, agree who owns what before it matters. None of them requires anyone to become a better person.

One of my students put it in a sentence I have stolen for every class since: the conflict was scheduled before we ever met. The delivery date, the KPIs, the unwritten ownership of that one task — the collision was on the calendar. The only open question was how the humans would handle the impact. That question is the subject of the rest of this book.

“The conflict was scheduled before we ever met.”

◆ TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ◆ Most workplace conflict is structural, not personal. Different scoreboards plus one shared deadline equals collision — no villains required.
- ◆ Conflict peaks around schedules, priorities and resources. Genuine personality clashes are rarer than we think, and blaming personality hides the real cause.
- ◆ Friction in a new team is often a development stage, not a breakdown. Teams that never push back on each other usually haven't started being honest yet.

- ♦ Functional conflict surfaces information and improves the system. Dysfunctional conflict destroys information and teaches people to hide problems.
- ♦ The fork between the two appears early: the moment the conversation shifts from "who caused this" to "what do we do now" — and whether anyone fixes the system afterwards.

2

CHAPTER 2

The Five Moves Everyone Makes

ONCE I ASKED MY STUDENTS, BEFORE any theory, to describe in one sentence what they actually did in their conflict. Not what they wished they had done. What they did.

The answers, once you strip the detail, collapse into a remarkably short list. I pushed back and won. We sat down and worked something out. We split the difference. I let it go. I gave them what they wanted. Forty-five unique stories; five underlying moves.

That is not an accident. In the 1970s, two researchers, Kenneth Thomas and Ralph Kilmann, mapped conflict behaviour onto two simple questions. How hard am I pushing for my own goal? That is assertiveness. And how much do I care about your goal? That is cooperativeness. Cross the two and you get five recognisable strategies. Half a century later, their map — the Thomas–Kilmann model — is still the standard, and the Project Management Institute bakes a version of it into how project managers are trained and examined.

Here is the map, with the plain-English version of each move.



FIGURE 2 · The five conflict modes (after Thomas & Kilmann)

Competing is high assertiveness, low cooperativeness: I win, you lose. Pulling rank, enforcing the rule, standing firm on the evidence, escalating to force a decision.

Collaborating is high on both: we dig until we find a solution that genuinely serves us both. Powerful, and expensive — it costs time, honesty and two willing parties.

Compromising sits in the middle: we both give something up to close the matter. Half the difference, split the cost, meet at the midpoint.

Avoiding is low on both: nobody engages. The issue is postponed, sidestepped, or quietly buried.

Accommodating is low assertiveness, high cooperativeness: you win, I yield. Sometimes generous, sometimes strategic, sometimes fear wearing a polite mask.

Every one of these five showed up in my collection, and seeing them in real stories teaches something no diagram can.

The five moves, as real people made them

Competing. An internal auditor — call him Sanjay — presented a set of control weaknesses to a company CEO. The CEO's response was to call every finding a false allegation, in front of both teams. Sanjay did not soften the report or offer to meet in the middle. He laid out the analysis, built entirely from the management's own reports, and let the documents speak. The CEO conceded, and the controls got fixed. Competing, done with evidence and a steady voice, was exactly right — the findings were either true or they were not, and splitting the difference on the truth is not a virtue.

Collaborating. In a five-person marketing project, a student — the storyteller called them Maya and Josh, so I will too — found her slide deck rewritten overnight in a completely different style, no warning, the night before a deadline. Messages flew; Josh got defensive. Then a teammate suggested a call instead of a text war. On the call, something shifted: Maya said her real issue wasn't the design at all, it was being cut out of a decision that affected her work. Josh admitted he should have asked. They blended the two designs — and the blend was better than either original. That is collaborating: slower, more honest and, when it lands, the only move on the list that leaves the relationship stronger than before the fight.

Compromising. A trade manager I'll call Chen received a shipment of goods from a long-term German supplier with defects that violated the contract. He asked for inspection reports before negotiating; the supplier refused, insisted the products were flawless, blamed Chen's warehouse and demanded compensation. Three weeks of argument by email and video call went nowhere, because there was no agreed way to establish the facts. In the end, both sides split all the costs fifty-fifty and got back to business. Nobody proved anything; nobody fully won. A compromise like that is a legitimate tool — it buys back the relationship and stops the bleeding — but notice what it doesn't do: it never establishes what actually went wrong, which means the same

fight is waiting in the next shipment. Chapter 8 returns to this story, because the missing ingredient wasn't goodwill. It was evidence.

Avoiding. A student — call him Wei — was the experienced professional in a postgraduate group project, so the others expected him to coordinate. When two teammates stopped delivering and a third went silent in the group chat, Wei made a decision that will be familiar to every capable person reading this: he stopped arguing and quietly did their work himself, documenting each person's contribution in case questions were asked later. The assignment was submitted on time and got a good grade. And the team was dead. His own words: everyone remained polite, but there was little trust or collaboration afterwards. Avoiding rarely looks like conflict, which is exactly why it is the most underestimated move on the map. Chapter 3 is entirely about it.

Accommodating. A student I'll call Lin wanted to leave her degree; she had lost all interest in the field. A family member she loved told her that leaving would end their relationship. After many painful arguments, Lin yielded — returned to the programme, finished it, graduated. Years later she wrote that she is genuinely grateful for the doors the degree opened, and, in the same paragraph, that the conflict still feels unresolved inside her. Accommodating is the move we make when the relationship matters more than the issue. Sometimes that is wisdom. Sometimes it is a bill that arrives years later. Usually it is both, and pretending otherwise is how bad advice gets written.

A menu, not a ladder

Here is the point I now teach before anything else, because everything in the next three chapters depends on it: these five moves are a menu, not a ladder. There is no best mode. There is only fit.

*The five moves are a menu, not a ladder.
There is no best mode — only fit.*

Somewhere along the way, most of us absorbed a ranking: collaborating is what good, evolved people do; competing is for bullies; avoiding is for cowards. My students carried exactly this ranking — you will remember that three quarters of them prescribed collaboration for someone else's conflict, whatever it was.

The stories say otherwise. Sanjay's competing saved a company from its own weak controls. Chen's compromise rescued a two-year business relationship that a longer war would have killed. There are moments when avoiding is right — when the issue is trivial, or when tempers need a night to cool before the real conversation. There are moments when accommodating is right — when you realise you are wrong, or when the issue matters far less to you than the person does. And there are moments, more than we like to admit, when collaboration is simply not available: when the other side holds all the power and no incentive, or when the "disagreement" is actually a rule being broken, and the correct response is not a workshop but an escalation.

Choosing the move that fits the situation — that is the actual skill. Not defaulting to the aggressive one because you're angry, or the polite one because you're tired, or the fashionable one because it sounds enlightened.

So how do you choose? Three questions do most of the work, and they take ten seconds each.

What are the stakes — for the task, and for the relationship? High-stakes task, low-stakes relationship (a one-off vendor dispute) points differently than low-stakes task, high-stakes relationship (your co-founder's formatting habits).

Do both sides have a reason to engage? Collaboration needs two willing parties and some overlap of interest. If the other side wins by ignoring you, no amount of empathy will conjure a win-win.

What does the clock say? Collaborating takes time. In a genuine emergency, a clean decision now — competing — is often kinder than a beautiful consensus next week.

Hold those three questions and the five moves stop being personality types and become tools. In the next four chapters, we will watch each tool used well and used badly — starting with the one that quietly did the most damage across my whole collection. It is not the one you would guess.

◆ TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ◆ Under every conflict style are two questions: how hard am I pushing my goal, and how much do I care about yours? The five answers are competing, collaborating, compromising, avoiding, accommodating.
- ◆ The five modes are a menu, not a ladder. No mode is morally superior; each fits certain situations and fails in others.
- ◆ Collaborating is the only move that can leave a relationship stronger than before — and the most expensive one. It needs time, honesty and two willing parties.
- ◆ Compromise closes disputes but doesn't establish facts. If the underlying question stays unanswered, the same conflict is waiting further down the road.
- ◆ Choose your move with three quick questions: what are the stakes for task and relationship, does the other side have any reason to engage, and how much time do we really have?

3

CHAPTER 3

Polite but Dead: The High Cost of Avoiding

OF THE FORTY-FIVE STORIES I collected, the ones that stayed with me longest had no shouting in them at all.

When I tallied how each story ended, a pattern jumped out that I did not expect. The conflicts that ended worst — team split in two, trust permanently gone, problems officially "solved" while everyone quietly stopped talking — were not dominated by the aggressive stories. They were dominated by the quiet ones. In my collection, nearly every ending I'd class as "task completed, relationship dead" traced back to somebody avoiding a conversation.

I started calling these outcomes polite but dead, and my students knew exactly what I meant. Everyone has worked on a team like that. The meetings are civil. The deliverables ship. And something essential — trust, honesty, the willingness to flag a problem early — has flatlined.

Let me show you how it happens, because it never happens loudly.

The silent rescuer

You met Wei briefly in the last chapter. His story deserves the full telling, because it is the most sympathetic version of avoiding I know — the version that feels, from the inside, like heroism.

Wei joined a four-person postgraduate group project. He was the one with years of marketing and project management experience, so the group naturally expected him to coordinate. Fine. Week one, everyone agreed to split the work equally.

By week two, two teammates had missed their commitments and a third had gone mostly silent in the group chat. The deadline crept closer. Wei, watching the assignment's quality sink toward the waterline, made the decision so many capable people make: rather than wait, he started completing other people's unfinished work himself.

When he reminded the group about deadlines, one member pushed back — said Wei was pressuring everyone, that people had different schedules and should work at their own pace. From Wei's side, adults should deliver what they promised. From their side, Wei was controlling and demanding. A real disagreement, out in the open, for a moment.

And here is the fork in the road. Wei looked at that flare of tension and made a choice: he decided to stop arguing. He put his head down, finished the remaining work himself, and kept a quiet record of who had contributed what, as insurance in case the lecturer ever asked.

On paper: triumph. Submitted on time. Good grade. If you were measuring this team by its deliverable, you would call it a success.

Wei's own verdict, written months later, is the most quietly devastating sentence in my collection: "Everyone remained polite, but there was little trust or collaboration afterwards."

Notice what avoiding did here. It did not merely leave the conflict unresolved — it prevented the information exchange that resolution would have required. The free-riding teammates never had to hear, plainly, that their behaviour was pushing one person to do a team's

work. Wei never got to hear whatever was actually going on in their lives — and in the stories where someone finally asked, there was almost always something going on: a new part-time job, a family situation, three deadlines stacked on one week. Four people finished a project together and learned nothing about each other except to stay polite and distant.

Wei knew it, too. His written reflection said that his mistake was spending his energy absorbing other people's work instead of addressing the communication problem early. He didn't lack the skill for that conversation. He lacked the conviction, in the moment, that it was his job to start it — because the deadline felt like the emergency, and the relationship felt like it could wait.

The deadline was never the real emergency. Deadlines pass. Teams continue.

The deleted group chat

If Wei's story is avoiding in its most sympathetic form, this next one shows the same move from the manager's chair — and how easily avoidance dresses up as professionalism.

A retail team leader — call him Dev — was, by his own account, a generous boss. He approved leave freely, covered a sick teammate's early shift himself, even prepared performance reports nobody had asked him to write. But one of his staff was underperforming: customer complaints, mistakes he wouldn't own, and CCTV footage showing he wasn't greeting customers. Dev responded by cutting the man's paid hours.

The team's group chat lit up with anger. And Dev — in his own written words — "was completely silent, because the team was not in good shape to understand my efforts."

Read that sentence again. It is the internal monologue of avoidance everywhere: they wouldn't understand, so why engage? Then, advised by senior management, Dev did something I have never seen

in a textbook but see constantly in real workplaces: he deleted the internal group chat entirely, leaving only the official channel where top management was present, where nobody would dare complain.

Silence achieved. Hours were now allocated by performance; sales numbers held up; the noise stopped. In Dev's telling, the conflict "ended smoothly."

Then, at the very end of his story, a confession of stunning honesty: "One thing I have ignored — whether they are working with satisfaction or not."

The classmate who analysed Dev's story anonymously wrote a diagnosis I could not improve on: the underperformer was judged on evidence he was never shown, by a leader whose invisible extra labour the team never saw — a double blindness, resolved by removing the room where anyone could talk about it. And she added five words that belong on a poster: "Silence was mistaken for resolution."

"Silence was mistaken for resolution."

That is the mechanism of polite-but-dead in a single line. Avoiding doesn't resolve conflict; it removes the evidence of it. The problem goes dark, not away. And people who can no longer complain to you do not stop complaining. They complain about you, somewhere you can't hear, while updating their CVs.

The ghostwriter proposal

One more, because it shows what happens when a whole group avoids — and how far a problem can drift while nobody talks.

A student I'll call Carlos was in a university group assigned a major case study. From the start, communication was thin: a group chat nobody answered, work nobody tracked. So the work flowed, silently

and predictably, to the most conscientious person. A week before the deadline, with roughly half the project done — most of it by Carlos — his teammates surfaced with a proposal that left him speechless: let's just pay someone to finish it.

Think about the sequence of avoided conversations required to arrive there. Nobody had said, in week one, "how are we splitting this, exactly?" Nobody had said, in week three, "I notice one person is doing everything." The disengaged members, rather than renegotiate the workload they had quietly abandoned, reached for a shortcut so extreme it risked everyone's academic standing. The first honest group conversation of the whole project was an argument about hiring a ghostwriter.

Carlos refused. The argument split the team in two — literally. Each half finished its own portion separately and reported the split to the lecturer. Nobody yelled, particularly. The team simply ceased to exist.

The anonymous classmate who analysed this story saw through it beautifully. The root cause, she wrote, was not that some people are lazy. It was a task-allocation and accountability vacuum: with no tracker, no check-ins and no agreed norms, work naturally piled onto the most responsible person until the imbalance became unbearable — and by then, every honest option felt too expensive. Avoidance compounds. Each skipped conversation makes the next one harder, until the only moves left on the table are the desperate ones.

When avoiding is actually right

I promised you the full menu, so let me defend avoiding for a moment, because it has legitimate uses and pretending otherwise produces guilt instead of skill.

Avoiding is right when the issue is genuinely trivial and the relationship isn't at stake. Not every irritation deserves a summit. Letting small things go is not avoidance; it is proportion.

Avoiding is right as a deliberate delay. One of the sharpest moves in my whole collection came from a student in a heated moment who asked for a pause — cooled down for a few hours, then sent a private message that reopened the conversation on completely different terms. (You will meet him properly in Chapter 10.) Stepping back from a conversation you are about to have badly is not cowardice. It is timing.

The test is simple: avoiding is a strategy when it has a return date. It is a symptom when it doesn't. Wei never scheduled the conversation he skipped. Dev deleted the room it would have happened in. Carlos's team deferred theirs until the only agenda item left was a ghostwriter. None of those silences had a return date, and all of them collected interest.

If you take one habit from this chapter, take this one: when you catch yourself deciding a conversation isn't worth having, say out loud when you will have it instead. "Not now" is fine. "Never," in a working relationship, is a decision to let the relationship die politely — and you should at least make that decision on purpose.

◆ TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ◆ The worst outcomes in real conflicts are often the quietest. "Task completed, relationship dead" almost always traces back to an avoided conversation, not a loud fight.
- ◆ Avoiding doesn't resolve conflict — it hides the evidence of it. Silence is not agreement, and calm is not peace.
- ◆ Capable people avoid by absorbing: doing others' work rather than raising the issue. It feels heroic and reliably kills the team.
- ◆ Managers avoid by controlling the channel: shutting down the venue where complaints happen and mistaking the quiet for resolution.
- ◆ Avoided conversations compound. Each one you skip makes the next harder, until only desperate options remain.
- ◆ Avoiding is legitimate only with a return date. "Not now, but Thursday" is strategy. "Not now" forever is a slow goodbye.

4

CHAPTER 4

Winning Battles, Losing People

IF AVOIDING KILLS TEAMS QUIETLY, competing kills them on the record.

In my collection, the stories where someone reached for force — pulled rank, invoked policy, escalated to authority, dug in and refused to move — have a distinctive ending. Mostly, somebody wins. And then, in story after story, the same phrase appears in the aftermath, in slightly different words each time: it was never the same again.

Force is seductive because it works, in the narrow sense. The overtime stopped being demanded. The deliveries stayed blocked. The performance plan was issued. If you measure only the issue, competing looks efficient. The stories invite you to measure something else: what it costs, who pays, and the one situation in which standing firm is not just acceptable but necessary.

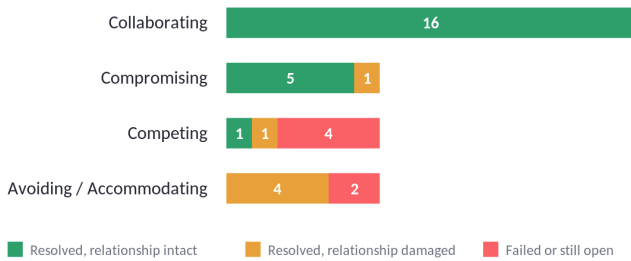


FIGURE 3 · How each mode actually ended

The overtime memo

A story from a large IT company. A delivery team was run by a leader under heavy pressure from her own bosses to hit deadlines. Company policy was explicit: overtime was voluntary. The team leader began treating it as anything but — handing out extra tasks late in the day with hints, sometimes plain statements, that staying back was expected.

One of her team — I'll call her Nadia — said no one evening. She had a personal commitment, and the policy was on her side. What followed was small, deniable and unmistakable: comments in team meetings questioning how serious Nadia was about her work, in front of colleagues. The costs of "voluntary" were being priced in publicly.

Nadia did it properly. She tried the direct conversation first, one on one, reminding her boss of the policy. The boss didn't budge — other people are staying, deadlines will slip, are you a team player or not? The policy question had been converted into a loyalty test, which is how power likes to reframe rules it finds inconvenient.

So Nadia escalated to HR, with dates and specific examples. Here is where the story gets instructive: HR investigated, and the boss defended herself smoothly — she had never ordered anyone to stay, her words were meant to motivate. On paper, almost nothing was provable. But the pattern was real enough that HR acted anyway,

sending the whole team a written reminder that overtime was strictly voluntary.

Victory. The policy was upheld, the pressure stopped, and the team leader became noticeably more careful.

And the relationship? Nadia's written words: "It was never the same as before. It became more formal and less friendly... a quieter, more distant working relationship that continued until I left that team."

I want to be precise about the lesson, because it is not "don't escalate." Nadia was right to escalate. A rule was being broken by the person with power over her; a collaborative workshop between unequal parties, one of whom is violating policy, is a fantasy. The lesson is about accounting. Competing spends relationship capital, win or lose. Sometimes the purchase is worth it — Nadia bought back her evenings and, probably, the whole team's. But nobody should walk into that transaction expecting the relationship to survive unbruised, and nobody should be surprised by the invoice.

Competing spends relationship capital, win or lose. Nobody should be surprised by the invoice.

The standoff nobody can win

Sometimes competing doesn't even buy a victory. It just buys a war.

In a company in Dubai, the accounts receivable department — a student I'll call Amal worked in it — held a firm rule: customers who missed agreed payments got their deliveries stopped until money or a post-dated cheque appeared. Cash flow pressure from the CFO made the rule non-negotiable. Meanwhile the sales team watched their targets burn as deliveries froze, and pleaded their customers'

cases. Without payment proof, Amal's department would not move: "we are firm with stopping the deliveries," her story says, in the present tense, because the conflict was still running when she wrote it.

Look at the structure. Finance is measured on cash and empowered to block. Sales is measured on volume and empowered to promise. Both sides pushed authority; neither could actually win, because neither controlled the other's scoreboard. The result was not resolution but a frozen front line, refought account by account, month after month.

The classmate who analysed Amal's story spotted the only real exit, and it wasn't a better attitude. The company had no agreed procedure for this entirely predictable collision: no credit thresholds visible to sales before they promised delivery, no shared dashboard of payment status, no routine meeting where risky accounts got discussed before they blew up. Two departments were duelling, case by case, over decisions a decent process would have made automatically. When a conflict repeats on schedule, it isn't really about the people in it — it is a system fighting itself. Chapter 9 picks this thread up.

The plan that read as a verdict

Return, briefly, to Marcus from Chapter 1 — the supervisor with the sleeping employee. I put him here because his story shows the subtler cost of force: it forecloses information.

Recall the sequence: quiet word, temporary improvement, relapse — then a formal performance improvement plan. Reasonable steps on paper. But by his own account, the employee had grown "indifferent to the feedback" before the PIP arrived, which is a signal worth pausing on: indifference from a previously fine employee usually means the real story hasn't surfaced yet. Health, burnout, a second job, night-time caregiving, something. The formal plan, whatever its intent, was read from below as a verdict — the start of being managed out. The man resigned rather than see it through.

Nobody in this story ever learned what the problem was. That is what force does at its worst: it ends the conversation in which the truth would have appeared. The peer who analysed Marcus's story suggested the fix was earlier joint problem-solving — sitting down at the second incident, not the fifth, and asking what is going on before reaching for the machinery. Once the formal process starts, candour becomes legally dangerous for both sides, and everyone retreats into scripts.

The exception: force with evidence

By now you might conclude competing is simply toxic. My collection contains exactly one unambiguous, everyone-agrees victory for it, and the exception teaches the rule.

Sanjay, the internal auditor from Chapter 2, sat across from a CEO who had just called his team's findings "false allegations." The power gradient was steep, the audience senior, the stakes reputational for both sides. Sanjay's team did not compromise, did not offer to soften the report, did not schedule a workshop. They stood firm — and walked the room through the evidence, every finding traced to reports the management had itself supplied. Hard to call your own data a false allegation. The CEO accepted the report; the recommended controls were implemented.

Why did competing work here when it burned everyone else? Three conditions, all present:

The question had a true answer. The control weaknesses were real or they weren't. This wasn't a preference dispute where meeting in the middle makes sense; splitting the difference on facts is just agreeing to be half wrong.

The evidence was overwhelming and independent of opinion. Sanjay didn't out-argue the CEO. He removed the need to argue.

Standing firm was the job. An auditor who softens findings under pressure is not being collaborative; he is failing at the one thing he is

paid for. Some roles — auditor, safety officer, doctor, quality gatekeeper — are hired specifically to compete with the organisation's wishful thinking.

Even then, notice: nobody described that CEO relationship as warm afterwards. The best case for competing still comes with an invoice; it is simply worth paying when truth, safety or policy is what's at stake.

So here is the rule my collection suggests. Compete when there is a fact or a rule at the centre, when you hold real evidence rather than a strong feeling, and when you are prepared — genuinely — to pay for the win in relationship currency. If any of the three is missing, you are not standing firm. You are just having a fight.

◆ TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ◆ Force usually wins the issue and taxes the relationship. Expect the invoice — "it was never the same again" is the standard aftermath, even for justified wins.
- ◆ Escalation is right when a rule is being broken by someone with power over you. You cannot collaborate someone into obeying policy — but escalate on evidence, not adjectives.
- ◆ When two sides both hold authority and neither controls the other's scoreboard, competing produces a standoff, not a victory. Repeating conflicts are a missing process, not a bad colleague.
- ◆ Formal machinery (warnings, PIPs, penalty clauses) reads from below as a verdict, and ends the conversation where the truth would have surfaced. Ask "what's going on?" before you reach for it.
- ◆ Competing is the correct move when the question has a true answer, your evidence is solid, and holding the line is literally your job. Then stand firm — calmly, with the documents open.

5

CHAPTER 5

The Collaboration Reflex

NOW WE COME TO THE FINDING THAT made me write this book, the one from the Introduction: asked which approach should have been used in a classmate's conflict, three quarters of my students gave the same answer — collaborate — almost regardless of what the conflict was.

Remember the design of the exercise. These weren't people defending their own behaviour. Each was analysing a stranger's story, anonymously, with no stake in the outcome and every reason to be sharp. Many of their analyses were sharp — genuinely insightful about causes and stakeholders. And then, at the question of what should have been done, the sharpness dissolved into the same word, forty analyses running: collaborating would have been better. Zero recommended competing. One, exactly one, recommended avoiding.

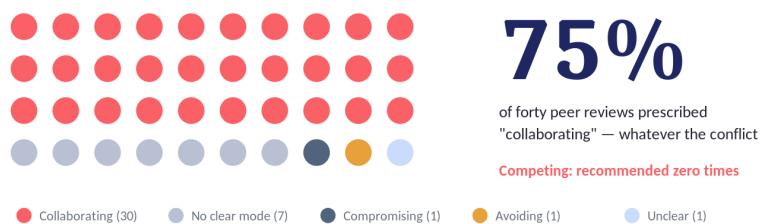


FIGURE 4 · What forty peer reviews prescribed

I don't think my students are unusual. I think they had absorbed, as most modern professionals have, a moral ranking of the five modes: collaboration is what enlightened people do, and everything else is a character flaw wearing a strategy's name. Twenty years of leadership books, workshops and LinkedIn posts have turned one tool on a five-tool bench into the only respectable answer.

I call it the collaboration reflex, and I want to spend this chapter showing you — using their own stories — the situations where the reflex gives genuinely bad advice.

When the other side wins by ignoring you

Go back to Amal's standoff between finance and sales. Several analyses of stories like hers prescribed the standard remedy: the departments should have collaborated on a win-win.

Ask the practical question the reflex skips: what, exactly, would finance gain by softening a credit hold? Their scoreboard is cash flow. Their instruction from the CFO is unambiguous. Releasing deliveries to a non-paying customer is, from their side, pure loss dressed up as teamwork. Collaboration requires overlapping interests and mutual incentive — some reason, on both sides, to invest in a joint answer. Where one side wins by simply ignoring the other, no facilitated conversation will conjure that overlap out of the air.

What would actually help — the analysing student saw this clearly — is rules: credit thresholds sales can see before promising, a shared

dashboard, an escalation path with teeth. Notice what that is. It isn't warmth. It's structure imposed on a recurring collision so that individual goodwill stops being the load-bearing wall. Sometimes the collaborative-sounding answer is a workshop, and the correct answer is a policy.

When it's not a disagreement, it's a violation

Second case: Nadia and the overtime. If you squint, it looks like a difference of opinion about workload, and the reflex duly suggests the two of them should have sat down and found a mutual understanding.

But there was no legitimate disagreement to mediate. Company policy said voluntary; the boss's behaviour said mandatory. That is not a conflict of perspectives — it is a violation with a power gradient. Inviting the two parties to co-create a solution quietly converts a rule into a negotiation, and hands the more powerful party a discount on compliance. Some things must not be split down the middle: policy, safety, law, integrity. When one side is breaking the rules, the respectable moves are competing and escalation — done, as Nadia did, with specifics and evidence. The collaboration reflex, applied here, is not generosity. It is capitulation with better manners.

Applied to a broken rule, the collaboration reflex is not generosity. It is capitulation with better manners.

When the other side refuses the table

Third: Sanjay's CEO, who opened the meeting by calling the findings false allegations. More than one student, analysing that story, wrote

that a collaborative approach from the start — walking through concerns together, jointly analysing the control gaps — would have produced less friction.

It's a lovely thought, and the CEO had declined it in the first sentence of the meeting. Collaboration is an offer that the other party has to accept. Extending the offer is usually right; assuming it will be accepted is not a strategy. Against a party in full defensive denial, what moved the room was not a warmer invitation but evidence that made denial untenable. Offer the table by all means — and know what you'll do when the other side flips it.

When good enough already happened

The subtlest version of the reflex appeared in the analyses of Chen's German supplier dispute — the fifty-fifty cost split from Chapter 2. Reviewer after reviewer marked it down: collaboration would have established true liability, prevented recurrence, produced a fairer number than an arbitrary halving.

All true. And consider what the fifty-fifty actually achieved: it ended a three-week transcontinental argument, preserved a two-year commercial relationship, and let both businesses get back to making money. A joint root-cause investigation across two companies, two languages and one contested shipment would have cost weeks more and might have ended the relationship it was meant to perfect. Compromise is not failed collaboration. It is a different tool — the right one when the clock is loud, the parties are roughly equal and the relationship is worth more than the delta between "fair" and "half."

Perfection has a price, and one of the most adult judgments in conflict is deciding the price is too high.

Why the reflex persists — and its price

If the reflex misleads, why is it so universal? Partly because collaboration genuinely is the most powerful mode when its

conditions are met — Chapter 2's Maya-and-Josh story shows it producing an outcome better than either side's original position, which no other mode can do. Partly because recommending it is socially safe: nobody's performance review ever suffered for suggesting a win-win. "You should have collaborated" is criticism that flatters everyone, including the critic.

But the reflex has a real price, and it lands hardest on people in weak positions. Tell someone whose boss is breaking policy that the answer is a better mutual conversation, and you have handed the strong party a shield. Tell a team facing a counterpart with no incentive to move that they need more empathy, and you have prescribed effort where structure was needed. The reflex is not just imprecise; it systematically favours whoever benefits from nothing changing.

So here is a discipline I now impose in class, and recommend to you. Before prescribing collaboration — to yourself or anyone else — check its three entry conditions: real overlap of interests, willingness on both sides, and enough time to do the slow work. All three present? Collaborate, wholeheartedly; nothing else comes close. Missing one? Say which one, out loud, and choose the mode that fits what is actually in front of you. If a friend describes a conflict and you hear yourself say "you two should really sit down together" — pause, and make sure you aren't just reciting the era's favourite answer.

The most useful thing I can tell you about the five modes is also the least fashionable: sometimes the wise move is to stand firm, sometimes it is to split the difference, sometimes it is to let it go entirely. Anyone who tells you one answer fits every conflict is not describing conflict. They are describing fashion.

◆ TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ◆ "Collaborate" has become the reflex answer to every conflict — in my collection, three quarters of all recommendations, regardless of fit. An answer that fits every question has stopped being an answer.

- ♦ Collaboration has entry conditions: overlapping interests, willingness on both sides, and time. Check all three before prescribing it.
- ♦ Where one side wins by ignoring you, the fix is structure — rules, thresholds, escalation paths — not a warmer conversation.
- ♦ Rule violations are not disagreements. Collaborating over a broken policy converts compliance into a negotiation and rewards the violator.
- ♦ Collaboration is an offer the other side can refuse. Extend it, and know your next move if the table gets flipped.
- ♦ A timely compromise that saves the relationship can beat a perfect resolution that arrives too late. Good enough, on time, is a legitimate outcome.

6

CHAPTER 6

Resolved Is Not Repaired

ONE OF THE STORIES IN MY COLLECTION was analysed by a classmate who concluded, in writing, that it had been "resolved perfectly, in the correct manner."

Here is the story that earned that verdict.

A student — I'll call her Lin — was partway through an undergraduate degree when she realised she had lost all interest in her field. She wanted to leave. A family member she loved disagreed so fiercely that the argument escalated to an ultimatum: leave the degree and we are finished, permanently. After many rounds of fighting, Lin gave in. She returned to the programme, completed it, graduated. Years later, she can honestly write that she is grateful — the degree opened doors that mattered.

She can also write this, in the same story: "Although the conflict was resolved in the end... it still feels like an unresolved emotional issue for me." She still wonders, sometimes, who she would have become on the other path.

Resolved perfectly. You see the problem.

The reviewer wasn't being lazy — he was using the only scorecard most of us ever learned. Did the fighting stop? Did an outcome get

delivered? Then it's resolved; file closed. By that scorecard, Lin's conflict scores full marks: degree finished, family intact, gratitude on record. The scorecard just has no row for the thing Lin actually told us: that the file never closed inside her.

This chapter is about fixing the scorecard, because bad measurement of conflict outcomes is not a philosophical problem. It decides which behaviours your team learns to repeat.

Two axes, four endings

When I coded the endings of all forty-five stories, one axis was never enough. I needed two.

Axis one: did the task get sorted? The project shipped, the policy was enforced, the money was split, the roster was fixed. Call it task resolution.

Axis two: would these people willingly work together again? Not politely coexist — willingly choose each other. Call it relationship repair.

Cross them and you get four endings. Both achieved — the real wins: twenty-four of my forty-five, though self-reporting probably flatters that number. Task done, relationship dead — the polite-but-dead quadrant: six clear cases. Neither — open wounds, teams split, resignations: at least four. And a scattering too murky to call.

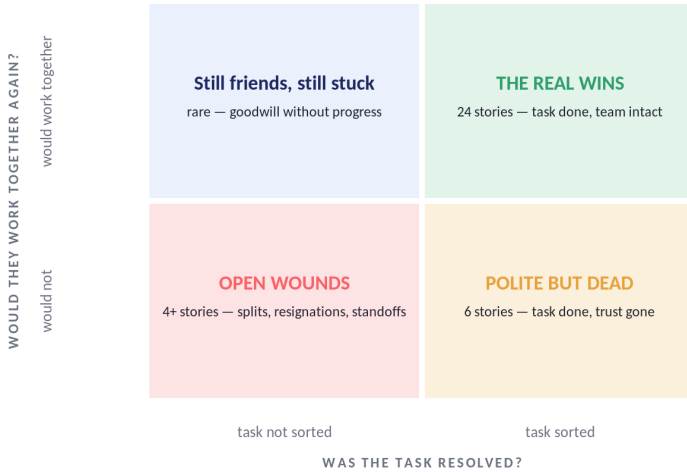


FIGURE 5 · The two axes of a real resolution

The six in that second quadrant are the ones this chapter cares about, because on every conventional dashboard they are indistinguishable from the twenty-four. The project shipped. The dispute closed. Management moved on. The only people who know the difference are the two who no longer quite look at each other in meetings — and every colleague quietly recalibrating what happens here when you speak up.

That recalibration is the hidden cost. A conflict that ends task-done-relationship-dead doesn't just damage two people; it publishes a lesson to everyone watching. Raise a problem, lose a friend. The next problem gets raised later, or never. You met the compounding version of that in Chapter 3.

What "never the same" looks like

The phrase kept surfacing in the stories, in different uniforms.

Nadia, after her justified, successful escalation over forced overtime: "The relationship was never the same as before... more formal and less friendly... until I left that team." Note the ending of that sentence.

The relationship outlived the conflict by exactly as long as it took her to transfer out.

A construction coordinator — call her Omar's colleague; you'll meet Omar properly in Chapter 8 — won her blame dispute outright, with written evidence. Her story still ends: "The working relationship recovered over time, though there was some lingering caution between us whenever schedule risks came up." Won the argument; pays a small tax on every future interaction.

Wei's project group: polite, distant, done. Dev's retail team: quiet, compliant, unreadable — by design.

None of these show up in any metric your organisation currently collects. Which is why the repair work, when it happens, almost never happens by procedure. It happens because one person decides the relationship is a deliverable too.

The apology that saved a team

Here is what deliberate repair looks like, in the story I now teach as the counterweight to all of the above.

A three-person analytics group — a student I'll call Tan, plus two teammates — had split a major assignment cleanly: data cleaning, dashboard, final model and report. Drafts were due to the shared drive on Wednesday night. Tan and one teammate delivered; the third, buried under two other deadlines she hadn't mentioned, sent half a dataset and went quiet. Without her columns nothing else could proceed, and the submission clock read forty-eight hours.

Tan did what stressed people do: he called her out in the group chat — publicly, sharply, with a suggestion that the others take over her work. She went defensive, refused help, insisted she'd finish alone, then stopped replying altogether. A public accusation had produced a private shutdown. Standard trajectory; you already know where this ends. Polite. Dead.

Except Tan did something in the next few hours that almost nobody in my collection did. He cooled down and sent her a private message — apologising for his tone. Not for the concern; the concern was legitimate. For the tone, and the venue.

Everything turned on that message. She replied with what she couldn't say in the group thread: the two hidden deadlines. He asked what she could realistically finish; she said the core columns, overnight. The other two split the remaining cleanup. All three stayed online through the night merging work, and submitted with an hour to spare.

Now, the detail that separates repair from rescue. After submission — after the adrenaline, when every group on earth mutters "never again" and disperses — this team held a short meeting and rebuilt their working agreement: milestone check-ins every two days, and a rule that anyone falling behind says so immediately, before the deadline makes it everyone's crisis. Tan's story ends with the sentence every project manager wants to write: they worked together on every subsequent project "with no more conflicts."

Same raw material as the disasters — a missed deadline, a public blowup, a defensive shutdown. Different ending, because of two deliberate acts: a private repair of the relationship, and a structural repair of the system that had let the surprise grow in the dark. Task axis, fixed. Relationship axis, fixed. That is what "resolved" ought to mean.

Closing the file properly

Let me give you the practical discipline, because it is small and cheap.

After any significant conflict — yours or your team's — score it on both axes, out loud. Is the task genuinely sorted? And would these people willingly work together again? If the second answer is no, or a hesitant maybe, the conflict is not over. You have a ceasefire, and

ceasefires without repair quietly convert into the polite-but-dead endings of Chapter 3.

A ceasefire is not a peace.

Repair, in the stories that managed it, was rarely elaborate. A private apology for tone, with the substance intact — Tan's move. An acknowledgement of what the other person had actually been carrying: the retail coworker in one story who, a week after a public spat, apologised unprompted once the pressure lifted, and was met halfway. A small process change made together, which does double duty — it prevents recurrence, and it signals we are still a team that builds things jointly.

And if you are the one reviewing someone else's conflict — as a manager, a mentor, or a friend — do not repeat the error of Lin's reviewer. Before pronouncing anything resolved, ask the second-axis question. "The fighting stopped" and "it's over" are different claims. The gap between them is where people keep their letters of resignation.

◆ **TAKE-HOME MESSAGES**

- ◆ Score every conflict on two axes: is the task sorted, and would these people willingly work together again? "Resolved" means both.
- ◆ Task-done-relationship-dead endings look identical to real wins on every dashboard. The difference lives in the next problem nobody raises.
- ◆ Every conflict ending publishes a lesson to bystanders about what speaking up costs here. That lesson compounds far beyond the two people involved.

- ♦ Repair is deliberate: a private apology for tone (not substance), an acknowledgement of what the other person was carrying, a process fix made together.
- ♦ The best teams close conflicts twice — once when the task ships, once when the working agreement is rebuilt so the same surprise can't grow in the dark again.
- ♦ Before calling anything resolved — including your own conflicts — ask the second question. A ceasefire is not a peace.

7

CHAPTER 7

The Argument Under the Argument

THE MOST QUIETLY USEFUL SENTENCE in all forty-five stories was written by a student about a fight over slide design.

You met the story in Chapter 2 — Maya, Josh, the deck rewritten overnight without asking, the night before a deadline. Text-message war, defensiveness, two bystanders keeping their heads down. Then a phone call, on which Maya said the thing that ended the fight in minutes: her issue was never the design. It was being cut out of a decision that affected her work.

The storyteller — a third teammate watching all this — closed with the sentence I'd frame: "Most conflict like this isn't really about the task. It's about feeling overlooked, and it settles once people feel heard."

That observation has a distinguished pedigree. In 1981, Roger Fisher and William Ury published *Getting to Yes*, still the most useful short book on negotiation ever written, and its central move is exactly this: distinguish positions from interests. A position is what someone says they want — put my design back. An interest is why they want it — respected, consulted, not blindsided at midnight. Positions are surface; interests are the argument under the argument.

The reason the distinction matters is mechanical, not sentimental. Positions are usually incompatible by construction — my design or yours, my deadline or your features, deliveries blocked or released. Argue at that level and someone must lose. Interests are frequently compatible even when positions are not. Maya's interest (be consulted) and Josh's interest (contribute boldly, be useful) could both be satisfied completely — and were, by a blended design plus a new rule that big changes get flagged in the chat first. The blend, both of them admitted, was better than either original. You cannot get that outcome by arguing positions. There is no compromise between "my version" and "your version" that beats both.

Two interns and a style war

Here is the distinction working in a quieter register, in a story I'll return to again in Chapter 10 because it contains two separate masterstrokes.

A developer — call him Ravi — joined a small product team as an intern. Another intern, three months his senior, reviewed his code before it went anywhere. No formal hierarchy; just the unspoken authority of a head start. And review by review, that authority curdled. Ravi's working code came back flagged for things written in no team standard: variable names, where to split a function. A one-day task stretched across a week. The breaking point was almost comic — the same block of code rejected twice, for opposite reasons.

Read this fight at position level and it's unwinnable. Position one: your code needs changing. Position two: my code is fine. Repeat until someone quits or a supervisor imposes a winner — who then becomes the villain of somebody's story.

Ravi went looking underneath instead. His own interest was obvious to him: predictable rules, so that "done" meant done. But he also — and this is the rarer move — took his rival's interests seriously. The senior intern's whole standing on that team was his three-month head start. Every style comment was, in part, that standing being

performed. Attack the comments in public, in the review thread, and you attack the standing; defensiveness was guaranteed.

So Ravi asked for ten minutes offline and laid out the pattern without accusation: the requests were inconsistent, and he couldn't tell which rules were real. Defensiveness first — then the senior intern admitted most of it was personal habit from how he'd been taught, not team standard. The fever broke there, in a two-metre conversation no audience ever saw.

What they did next belongs in Chapter 10, so I'll hold it. The point for now: at position level this was a fight about semicolons; at interest level it was predictability meeting status, and both interests were entirely satisfiable. Most "petty" conflicts are petty only at the surface. The interests underneath — respect, certainty, inclusion, fear of looking replaceable — are never petty, which is why "it's just formatting, let it go" is advice that never works on anyone.

The interests you can't see from your chair

One more layer, and it is the one the workplace stories kept insisting on: some interests are invisible from where you sit, and the fight exists precisely because nobody has said them out loud.

A healthcare data analyst — call her Farah — investigated why a hospital's insurance claims were suddenly being rejected. Her account manager, under fire from the client's board about falling revenue, demanded a quick report blaming a generic system glitch, just to calm everyone down. Farah wanted two more days in the raw data to find the real cause. In a team meeting, he publicly attacked her timeline as slow and unresponsive; she went defensive; positions locked. Glitch report now versus real answer later.

The classmate who analysed this story anonymously wrote the best single line of interest analysis in my collection: "Neither one was being unreasonable. They just had different things on the line." His board-facing panic was a real interest — his standing, maybe his job.

Her professional credibility was a real interest — sign a wrong glitch report and it's her name on it when the insurer disproves it. Two legitimate interests, invisible to each other, dressed up as a scheduling fight.

The resolution proved the compatibility: Farah worked late and produced a high-level interim update — enough to calm the client — while finishing the deep dive, which found the truth (a quiet policy change by the insurer, not a glitch). He got his fire blanket; she got her rigour; the client got an answer that was actually right. The analysing student's dry observation: she found the collaborative solution alone, after the blowup. Had either of them named their real interest in that meeting — I need the panic to stop today; I can't sign my name to a guess — the same two-track answer was available without anyone raising their voice.

That is the practical technique, and it is almost embarrassingly simple. In your next locked disagreement, say your interest, not just your position. Not "I need two more days" (position) but "I can't put my name on an answer I haven't verified — what does the client need in the meantime?" (interest, plus an invitation). And ask for theirs: what's driving the deadline pressure on your side? People argue positions for hours and surrender interests in one honest sentence — because positions feel safe to state and interests feel exposed. The exposure is the shortcut.

*People argue positions for hours — and
surrender interests in one honest sentence.*

One warning, before the summary. Interests explain behaviour; they do not automatically excuse it. Josh's interest in contributing didn't make the midnight rewrite acceptable, and the account manager's panic didn't make the public attack fair. Understand the interest, address the interest — and still, where needed, hold the line on

behaviour. The next three chapters are about exactly that: the habits and systems that let interests surface before they have to explode.

◆ **TAKE-HOME MESSAGES**

- ◆ A position is what someone demands; an interest is why. Positions are usually incompatible; interests very often are not.
- ◆ Fights about tasks are frequently about being overlooked. Inclusion in the decision is often the whole issue — and costs one message to provide.
- ◆ Take the other side's interests seriously, especially status and standing. A criticism that threatens someone's standing in public guarantees defensiveness; the same point made privately often lands.
- ◆ When positions lock, name your interest out loud and ask for theirs. One honest sentence shortcuts hours of positional trench warfare.
- ◆ Look for the two-track solution: many "either/or" deadlocks (fast answer vs right answer, bold vs consulted) dissolve into "both" once the real interests are on the table.
- ◆ Understanding an interest explains behaviour; it doesn't excuse it. Address the interest and still hold the line on conduct.

8

CHAPTER 8

The Quiet Power of Receipts

IF YOU ASKED ME, BEFORE I RAN this exercise, what resolves workplace conflict, I would have given you the standard answer: communication skills. Empathy, listening, the courage to have the hard conversation. Ask better questions, hear the interest under the position — Chapter 7, more or less.

Then I read the stories, and a different hero kept walking on stage. Six separate conflicts in my collection ended not because anyone communicated beautifully, but because somebody produced a record. A log. A timestamp. A saved message. A dataset. In the stories, the person holding paper beat the person holding a better argument, every single time it came up.

I now teach this under a name my students immediately understand: receipts.

The receptionist's log

The purest version. A receptionist — call her Sofia — spent her days scheduling appointments and passing messages to staff. A coworker from another department began accusing her, increasingly loudly, of failing to forward his messages; he had missed client calls and wanted

a culprit. In reality he had been ignoring the messages in his own queue. Classic blame dispute: her word against his, and he had the louder voice and — when he raised it in an open office — the bigger audience.

Feel how tempting the losing moves are from her chair. Argue back publicly: now it's a scene, and onlookers remember heat, not facts. Absorb it quietly: Chapter 3, avoidance interest accruing. Escalate immediately with no proof: her word against his in front of a supervisor too.

Sofia did something better. She proposed — calmly, to his face — a shared message log: every message she forwarded, written down with the time. Notice the frame: not a weapon, a system, something that protects both of us from confusion. He could hardly object to accountability without looking like a man who preferred the fog. She also mentioned the situation to her supervisor once, factually, not as a complaint but so the pattern was on record.

The log ran quietly for days. Awkward, distant days — he was short with her; she stayed professional. Then the supervisor reviewed it, timestamps against outcomes, and the question answered itself: every message forwarded, on time, every day. The coworker apologised — privately, and by his own choice — and admitted the pressure he'd been under had gone looking for a target. The log stayed on permanently, and the two of them worked together fine afterwards.

Sofia never once argued her innocence. That is the detail to sit with. She built a small machine that argued it for her, continuously, without emotion, in a format nobody could shout at. In a blame dispute, the person with timestamps wins without raising their voice.

*In a blame dispute, the person with
timestamps wins without raising their
voice.*

Three more receipts

The shuttle data. At a manufacturing site, a production supervisor stormed at HR demanding written warnings: his team had developed a lateness problem. The HR officer — call her Hana — noticed something in the dates. The lateness began exactly when the company had changed its staff shuttle timings. In the meeting, accused of "always protecting workers," she didn't debate philosophies of discipline. She put the shuttle data on the table. The correlation was undeniable; punishing workers for the transport department's decision was suddenly, visibly absurd. They fixed the shuttle schedule first and paused all warnings; lateness dropped; and — rare in my collection — the two of them ended with a stronger working relationship than before, because the fight had been settled by facts rather than surrender.

The saved warning. A construction coordinator — Omar — learned a materials delivery would slip, and messaged the site supervisor two days ahead: push back the subcontractor's start date. The supervisor kept the schedule anyway; materials didn't arrive; a full paid crew stood around an empty site for a day, and the client noticed. In the blame meeting, the supervisor pointed at Omar and procurement. Omar didn't argue. He produced the message, with its date. The conversation changed instantly — from who failed to how do we stop confirming crews before materials are verified, which became a company rule. His only regret, in his written story, was relying on chat apps for decisions that deserved formal records — the receipt worked, but he'd been lucky it existed.

The auditor's mirror. Sanjay's story is fundamentally a receipts story: an executive shouting "false" at findings assembled from his own company's reports. The evidence didn't need advocacy; it needed unveiling.

And one preventive variant worth its place: the sales rep from earlier chapters — the disputed factory client — walked into his showdown holding the CRM entry and the logged call recording that proved he'd engaged the client first. The commission argument that could have consumed weeks was settled by the manager in one meeting, because the record made the sequence undebatable. That receipt was created before any conflict existed, by a rep who simply logged things properly. The best receipts usually are.

Why paper beats argument

It's worth being precise about the mechanism, because "keep records" sounds like bureaucratic advice and this is not that.

A blame dispute is not primarily a factual argument. It is two nervous systems under threat, each defending a self-image, with an audience keeping score. In that arena, better arguing frequently makes things worse — every point you win raises the other side's cost of backing down. What a record does is remove the argument from the arena. The log, the timestamp, the dataset — none of them accuses anyone. They just sit there being true. The other person gets to update their position without surrendering to you; they're surrendering to a spreadsheet, which costs almost nothing in face. Sofia's accuser apologised on his own; Hana's supervisor u-turned in the meeting itself. Receipts don't just win disputes. They let the other side lose gracefully — which, if you remember Chapter 6's two axes, is half the game.

There is also a preventive effect. Where records exist, blame disputes tend not to start. The fog is where accusation lives; visible, shared, timestamped work is fog removal. That's why this chapter's habit

compounds so well with Chapter 10's trackers and written agreements.

Now, three honest cautions — because receipts are a power tool with a kickback.

Keep them to defend, not to prosecute. The moment record-keeping becomes ammunition-gathering against a colleague, trust is already gone and everyone can smell it. Sofia's log protected a process. Wei, back in Chapter 3, logged his teammates' contributions as quiet insurance — legitimate, but notice it repaired nothing; a receipt can protect you inside a dying relationship without saving the relationship.

Produce them to redirect, not to humiliate. Omar's message changed the meeting because he framed it as let's fix the process, not I told you so. The same evidence, delivered as a public gotcha, converts your vindication into the other person's grievance — and Chapter 6 taught you what that costs downstream.

And write things down before you need to. The deepest version of this habit isn't keeping proof; it's making agreements so clear, so early, that proof never has an argument to settle. Which brings us to communication as a designed system — the subject of the next chapter.

◆ TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ◆ In blame disputes, records beat rhetoric. The person with timestamps wins without raising their voice — six conflicts in my collection ended exactly this way.
- ◆ Evidence lets the other side back down gracefully: people who won't surrender to an opponent will surrender to a spreadsheet. That protects the relationship, not just your case.
- ◆ Propose records as a system that protects everyone ("so nothing gets lost"), never as a weapon aimed at someone. The framing decides whether it de-escalates or provokes.

- ♦ Deliver receipts to redirect the conversation toward fixing the process, not toward humiliating the person who was wrong.
- ♦ The best receipts exist before the conflict does: logged decisions, confirmed agreements, visible work. Where the record is clear, blame has nowhere to grow.
- ♦ Chat apps are where agreements go to get lost. If a decision matters, put it somewhere formal, dated and findable.

9

CHAPTER 9

Communication Is a System, Not a Talent

SOMEWHERE IN YOUR ORGANISATION, right now, there is a promise that exists only in the air.

In my collection, that promise belonged to a bank employee I'll call Jonas. He was posted to a branch ninety kilometres from home — hard, but temporary, because his area director gave him his word: one year, then back. Nothing on paper. A year passed. The director declined to honour the promise.

What strikes me about Jonas's story is his sentence about why it hurt: "In every workplace, communication and promises are sacred instruments." He eventually got his transfer, after a long-delayed sit-down in which the director actually heard his reasons — but he got it as a favour granted, not a commitment honoured. For a year, his working life hung on another man's memory and mood. A promise that lives in the air is not an agreement. It is a hope with a deadline attached.

A promise that lives in the air is not an agreement. It is a hope with a deadline attached.

I open with Jonas because this chapter makes an argument that sounds boring and is actually the highest-leverage idea in the book: most of the conflicts in my collection were communication failures before they were conflicts. And communication failures are not mainly talent problems — shy people, poor phrasing, missing charisma. They are design problems. Which is wonderful news, because design can be fixed on a Tuesday, whereas talent takes a lifetime.

Where the collisions actually came from

Run back through the stories with a designer's eye.

The vendor and the client who nearly ruined a long partnership arguing over who was responsible for producing a regulatory report — because responsibility after the handover phase had never been written down anywhere. Both sides were sincere. Both remembered the same history differently. There was no document to check, so there was only competing memory, escalating politely toward lawyers.

The two sales reps fighting over one factory client — because the company maintained two ownership rules simultaneously (first to log the lead; territory owner takes downtown) and had never reconciled them. Two people behaved correctly by the rule that favoured them. The system had scheduled that fight.

An administrative officer asked by one department's leader to post a festival notice — then interrogated by a different department that

considered the task theirs. Her conflict took minutes; the missing role clarity that caused it had been missing for years.

Omar's idle construction crew: a schedule confirmed on a hunch, over a warning delivered in a chat app, in a company running informal communication for formal decisions.

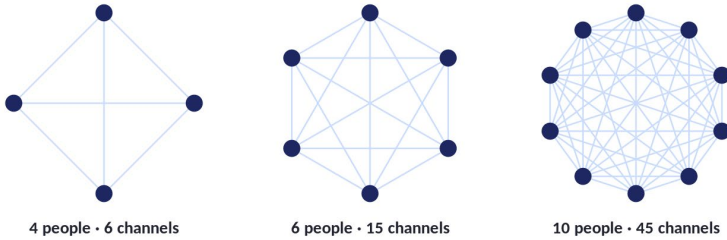
None of these people needed empathy training. They needed things written down, roles made explicit, one channel where decisions live, and a routine that checks reality before reality arrives. That is a communication system, and project management as a discipline has been quietly refining the checklist for decades — the Project Management Institute's body of knowledge devotes an entire knowledge area to it. Strip the jargon and it comes down to three verbs.

Plan: decide, before work starts, who needs what information, when, in what form, from whom. Not "we'll stay in touch" — actual answers. Where do decisions get recorded? Who must be told when a date moves? What goes in writing?

Manage: actually produce and distribute it — the status update, the decision log, the written confirmation, in the agreed channel, at the agreed rhythm.

Monitor: check that it landed. Sent is not received; received is not understood; understood is not agreed. Silence, in particular, is not consent — it is a signal to investigate. Every free-rider story in Chapter 3 incubated inside somebody's unanswered group chat, misread as "probably fine."

There is even arithmetic for why this gets hard so fast. Communication channels between n people number $n \times (n-1) / 2$. A four-person team has six channels to keep honest. Add a vendor, a second team, a steering group — a ten-person project has forty-five. Every unmanaged channel is a place where "I assumed you knew" breeds. Past about five people, winging it isn't optimism. It's negligence with better branding.



channels = $n(n-1)/2$ — every line is a place where “I assumed you knew” can breed

FIGURE 7 · Why communication breaks as teams grow

The team that designed its way out

Lest this sound like paperwork worship, here is the chapter's centrepiece — a story where communication design didn't prevent the conflict but completely transformed what the conflict cost. It is also my favourite ending in the whole collection, because everyone was right and it still nearly went wrong.

A bank was days from releasing a major enhancement to its core system. The digital banking team needed the release shipped on schedule — customer commitments and business deadlines hung on it. The IT support team wanted it postponed: user acceptance testing had surfaced defects that were not yet resolved, and they would be the ones fielding a production disaster at 2 a.m. The external vendor insisted the system was stable enough. Business operations stood in the middle, wanting both customer satisfaction and a bank that worked.

Four parties, four legitimate scoreboards, one binary decision, days to make it. In most organisations this resolves by volume or by rank — whoever shouts loudest or sits highest picks a date, and the losing team quietly roots for disaster so they can say told you.

This group — a student I'll call Dilshan was inside it — did something almost anticlimactically sensible. They convened everyone and

changed the question. Not should we release — a question built for trench warfare — but what, specifically, is unresolved, and how bad is each item, really? They walked the defect list one item at a time, scoring business impact and technical risk. And the binary dissolved on contact: high-risk defects would be fixed before release; low-risk ones were documented into the next update; regression tests were run on the fixes; and a rollback plan was written in case reality disagreed with the risk scores anyway.

The release went out with the agreed changes. No major incidents. And notice the shape of the resolution — it is Chapter 7's positions-versus-interests, industrialised. Positions: ship versus delay. Interests: deadline credibility versus operational safety. The defect-by-defect review was simply a machine for serving both interests at once, and the rollback plan was humility, written down.

The classmate who analysed Dilshan's story extracted exactly the right prevention list, and it is pure communication design: agree release criteria before you're standing at the gate; keep a shared risk register so nobody is surprised at the deadline; review test results with every stakeholder as they emerge, not in one apocalyptic meeting at the end. The conflict at the gate was survivable because the machinery for talking about risk already half-existed. The teams that improvise that machinery during the crisis usually build a scapegoat instead.

Communication debt

Software engineers have a phrase, technical debt: shortcuts that feel free today and charge compound interest later. My collection convinced me that communication debt deserves equal billing. Every undocumented promise (Jonas), every unreconciled rule (the duelling sales reps), every unclear ownership (the festival notice), every decision living in a chat scroll (Omar's schedule) is a small borrowed sum. It stays invisible while things go well — nobody audits communication during the good weeks. Then a delivery slips, a client

escalates, a deadline lands, and the debt gets called, always at the worst moment, always with interest, and always denominated in the currency of Chapter 6: relationships.

You now have the repayment method — plan, manage, monitor — and you have arithmetic that says start before the team grows. What remains is the concrete practice: which agreements to write, which rhythms to run, which records to keep. That is Chapter 10, where my students — who lived every failure in this book — tell you exactly what they would build first.

◆ TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ◆ Most conflicts are communication failures first: promises kept in the air, roles never written, two rules nobody reconciled, decisions buried in chat scroll.
- ◆ Communication failure is a design problem, not a talent problem — which means it can be fixed by structure this week, not by charisma someday.
- ◆ Three verbs make the system: plan who needs what, when, in what form; manage the actual flow; monitor that it landed. Sent is not understood, and silence is never consent.
- ◆ Channels grow as $n(n-1)/2$. Four people have six channels; ten have forty-five. Past a handful of people, informality is a rounding error away from negligence.
- ◆ When a binary decision splits legitimate interests, change the question: itemise, score the risks together, fix what's dangerous, document the rest, and write the rollback plan.
- ◆ Communication debt compounds quietly and gets called at the worst moment. Every promise on paper, every owner named, every decision logged is debt paid down early — cheaply.

10

CHAPTER 10

The Playbook: Eight Habits That Prevent Most Conflicts

THE FINAL QUESTION IN MY EXERCISE asked students to step into the project manager's chair for the story they had analysed: what practices would have prevented this conflict, or caught it early?

I read forty answers, expecting variety. I got convergence. The same practical ideas, arriving from the analyst reviewing a factory dispute and the sales rep reviewing a flatmate war. When people who have lived through conflict are asked how to prevent it, they reach — independently, repeatedly — for the same short list of machinery.

Here is that list, ranked roughly by how often it appeared and how much it would have saved. Nothing in it requires budget, software, or permission from anyone senior. That is the point. These are Tuesday-morning habits, not transformation programmes.



FIGURE 8 · The eight habits

1. Scheduled check-ins — because problems found early are cheap

The single most-prescribed practice in the collection, named in about a third of all analyses. Tan's analytics team, after their near-catastrophe, instituted milestone check-ins every two days — and never had another conflict. Multiple free-rider disasters incubated precisely because no routine moment existed where "how's your part going?" was a normal, blame-free question; the first status check was the deadline itself.

The mechanism: a check-in converts surprise into information. A teammate who is behind on Tuesday is a resource problem you can solve; the same teammate behind on deadline night is a betrayal you can only resent. Same fact — different week, different conflict.

Make it real: fixed rhythm, fifteen minutes, three questions per person — what's done, what's next, what's in the way. The third question is the whole product.

For the slide, if you ever teach this: problems found at a check-in cost hours; problems found at the deadline cost the relationship.

2. A shared, visible tracker — because visible work needs no accusations

From Trello boards to a shared spreadsheet to — my favourite — the expense tracker that ended a war between two couples sharing a flat. Rent transfers kept arriving late; chores kept sliding; the resident couple kept covering, resentment compounding nicely. After the blowup, the four of them built a shared digital expense sheet with fixed payment deadlines and a rotating, written cleaning roster. The household ran smoothly from then on — the occasional gentle reminder notwithstanding.

The mechanism: a tracker de-personalises accountability. Nobody has to say "you didn't pay" — the sheet says it, neutrally, to everyone, before the arrears grow teeth. It is Chapter 8's receipts, running in prevention mode: fog removal, so blame has nowhere to grow.

Make it real: one place, visible to all, updated as part of the work itself. If updating the tracker is extra work, it will die; if it is how work is claimed and closed, it will live.

Slide version: if progress is visible to everyone, nobody has to accuse anybody.

3. Written agreements before work starts — because verbal agreements are future conflicts

Jonas's air-borne transfer promise. The vendor and client who each sincerely remembered a different scope. The two sales-ownership rules that duelled until a manager had to referee. The style-guide vacuum that let one intern's taste govern another's output. Chapter 9 gave you the theory; the students' prescriptions were unanimous on

the practice: write it down before it matters. Roles. Scope. Ownership rules. Payment deadlines. Response-time norms. Definition of done.

The mechanism: a written agreement is cheap arbitration, purchased in advance. When memories diverge — and under pressure they always diverge, honestly, in each rememberer's favour — the document answers, and no one has to win.

Make it real: end kickoff with one page — who owns what, what "done" means, when we check in, how we raise problems. Send it to everyone. That page will feel like bureaucracy for exactly as long as nobody needs it.

Slide version: a verbal agreement is a future conflict with a start date.

4. Keep timestamped records — because receipts end blame disputes

Chapter 8 entire, compressed: Sofia's message log, Hana's shuttle data, Omar's saved warning, Sanjay's audit trail. Six conflicts resolved by record rather than rhetoric.

Make it real: log decisions where they can be found, confirm verbal agreements in writing that day, and when accused unjustly, build the neutral system that proves the pattern — framed as protection for everyone.

Slide version: the person with timestamps wins without raising their voice.

5. Private before public — because audiences turn corrections into combat

Tan's public call-out produced defensiveness and silence; his private apology produced the truth and an all-night rescue. Ravi's ten-minute offline conversation succeeded where a public review-thread battle would have entrenched. The food-factory line worker who was

scolded harshly in front of the team froze; the supervisor's later intervention — explanation, pairing with a mentor, no audience — fixed in a week what shouting hadn't fixed at all. And on the other side of the ledger: the account manager who attacked Farah's timeline in a team meeting bought himself a defensive standoff he later had to apologise for.

The mechanism is Chapter 7's status interest: in public, a correction threatens standing, so the standing gets defended instead of the problem getting solved. Remove the audience and you remove the second conflict — the one about face — leaving only the solvable one.

Make it real: praise in public, correct in private, always in that order of visibility. If you blew it publicly, repair privately and fast; the apology-for-tone-not-substance move is the highest-leverage sentence in this book.

Slide version: public criticism creates a second conflict on top of the first.

6. Escalate the problem, not the person — because framing decides what the referee fixes

Ravi again, and the second masterstroke I promised in Chapter 7. After the offline conversation, he and the senior intern still needed a real standard — so they went to the supervisor together, and asked for a written style guide. Not "he keeps blocking my work": a request that would have produced a referee, a winner, a loser, and a grudge. A process request — which produced a document, and turned a gatekeeper into something closer to a mentor, because the ambiguity his authority had been feeding on was gone.

Contrast the escalations-by-accusation across the collection: they resolved issues and embittered people, Chapter 4's standard invoice. Nadia's HR escalation — necessary, evidence-based, correctly done — still cost the relationship. When the problem genuinely is a person

breaking rules, pay that price. But an astonishing share of "person problems" are process gaps wearing a face: no style guide, no ownership rule, no release criteria, no roster logic anyone could see.

Make it real: before escalating, rewrite your complaint once — same facts, but as a missing rule rather than a guilty colleague. "Can we get a written standard for X?" If the rewrite is honest, escalate that version. It fixes more and burns less.

Slide version: same facts, different container.

7. Early-warning norms — because "I'm going to be late" is the cheapest sentence in project work

Nearly every deadline disaster in the collection shared one feature: the person in trouble knew, sometimes for weeks, and said nothing. The teammate buried under two hidden deadlines. The researcher whose family situation quietly consumed the fortnight. The data-cleaner whose half-finished sheet ambushed the whole team at drafts-due. In each case the delay was survivable; the surprise was what detonated.

My students' prescriptions converged on making bad news cheap to deliver: an explicit rule that trouble is reported the moment it's visible, and — one reviewer's rule I'd steal for any team — if someone misses two check-ins, the project lead follows up immediately, personally, before the silence compounds. For that to work, the first person who confesses a slip must be met with logistics, not scolding; the team's reaction to bad news is a price signal everyone reads, and Chapter 6 taught you what happens when the price is public shame.

Slide version: the cheapest sentence in project management is "I'm going to be late." The most expensive is the same sentence, unsaid.

The cheapest sentence in project management is “I’m going to be late.” The most expensive is the same sentence, unsaid.

8. Change control — because if changing the plan is free, the plan is fiction

The business team that rewrote agreed calculation rules after development was done, torching weeks of work — analysed, correctly, as a missing change-request process rather than villainy. The scope fight between a developer and his teammate over features that were never in any signed-off list. Dilshan's bank release, where the machinery — release criteria, risk register, staged decisions — turned a four-way collision into engineering. Josh's midnight redesign, prevented forever after by one team rule: big changes get flagged in the chat before they happen.

The mechanism: change control isn't resistance to change; it's a speed bump that forces the sentence "this is a change, and changes have costs" to be said out loud while options still exist. Most scope conflicts are not caused by the change itself but by its arrival as a fait accompli.

Make it real: a lightweight rule any team can run — new requests get written down, costed in time, and explicitly traded ("in, and what falls out?") before anyone builds anything.

Slide version: if changing the plan is free, the plan is fiction.

Where to start

Eight habits is a list; nobody adopts a list. So start with the pair that pays fastest, this week: a fifteen-minute check-in rhythm, and one page of written agreements for whatever you're currently building.

Between them they quietly install most of the rest — the check-in creates the venue for early warnings, the page creates the record that prevents blame, and both make the private conversation easier because problems surface while they're still small enough to discuss calmly.

None of this is glamorous. That's rather the point. The forty-five stories contain almost no conflicts that demanded brilliance — they demanded a tracker, a page, a rhythm, and one honest conversation held a fortnight earlier than it was. The machinery in this chapter is how ordinary teams get to spend their drama budget on the work instead.

◆ TAKE-HOME MESSAGES

- ◆ Prevention converges: people who've lived through conflict independently prescribe the same machinery — check-ins, trackers, written agreements, records, private conversations, clean escalation, early warnings, change control.
- ◆ The two highest-leverage starters: a fixed fifteen-minute check-in rhythm, and a one-page written agreement at kickoff. Install those and the rest follow.
- ◆ Make bad news cheap. Teams that punish the messenger get their bad news at the deadline, with interest.
- ◆ Escalate process gaps, not people, whenever the honest rewrite allows it — "can we get a standard?" fixes more and burns less than "he's blocking me."
- ◆ Treat every change as a change: named, costed, traded. Surprises, not changes, are what start the fights.
- ◆ None of this needs budget or permission. It needs a page, a rhythm, and the discipline to keep both boring and alive.



CONCLUSION

Two Questions to Ask After Every Fight

NEAR THE END OF MY COLLECTION sits a story you have not heard yet, and I saved it deliberately, because it contains almost everything this book has tried to say — inside one weekend shift at a fast-food restaurant.

A student — call him Arun — worked the front counter at a fried-chicken place during a chronically understaffed weekend rush. A colleague on packing duty kept mixing up orders; the line slowed; a customer complained about a wrong meal. The packer's response was to blame Arun, out loud, for "rushing him." Arun, who knew where the delays were coming from, felt the injustice hot in his chest.

Here is everything he did. He pointed out the packing errors calmly — position stated, no theatrics. The shift manager stepped in, heard both sides in turn, and then did something structural: reassigned the roles so the packer focused only on packing while Arun handled customer communication. The line recovered. The shift ended fine, and the two of them were fine afterwards — the conflict simply never acquired a second storey. In his written reflection, Arun didn't dwell on who was right. He wrote that peak hours needed clearer task boundaries — a system observation, from the counter of a fast-food restaurant, sharper than half the management consulting I've read.

One small story, and look what's inside it: conflict arriving out of structure (understaffing and unclear roles, not bad people); a position ("you rushed me") with an interest underneath (a man drowning, looking for a rope); a mediator who fixed the process rather than convicting a person; both axes closed — task working,

relationship intact — before the shift ended. Nobody in that kitchen had read Thomas and Kilmann. They just did the simple things, in the right order, before the situation could compound.

That is, finally, what I took from all forty-five stories. Handling conflict well almost never looks like brilliance. It looks like a small set of unglamorous moves — made earlier than feels natural.

*Handling conflict well almost never looks
like brilliance. It looks like small,
unglamorous moves — made earlier than
feels natural.*

If you want the whole book in your pocket, carry the two questions from Chapter 6, and ask them after every conflict you touch, including the ones you only witness:

Is the task truly sorted — or just quiet?

And would these people willingly work together again?

If either answer is no, the conflict is still open, whatever the paperwork says. And if you want the whole book as instincts — six of them, for the road:

When you feel the flare of a fight arriving, look for the structure first. Ask what scoreboards are colliding before you ask who is being difficult.

Treat the five modes as a menu. Stand firm when a fact or rule is at the centre and you hold the evidence. Split the difference when the clock is loud and the relationship is worth more than the delta. Let small things go — with a return date. Yield when you're wrong. And when interests overlap and both sides will come to the table,

collaborate, because nothing else can turn a fight into a better answer than either side brought.

Distrust your own reflex to prescribe collaboration everywhere. Check its entry conditions like a professional, not a poster.

Say your interest, not just your position — one honest sentence is the shortcut — and take the other side's interests, especially the invisible ones, seriously enough to name.

Keep receipts, kindly. Write agreements before they're needed, log decisions where they can be found, and when blame arrives, let the timestamps speak while you stay warm.

And correct people the way you'd want it done: privately, specifically, early — with the apology-for-tone always in your back pocket, because you will get it wrong sometimes, and the repair is where teams are actually built.

My students handed me their worst weeks on anonymous pages, and the pages turned out to hold a curriculum. The conflicts were scheduled long before anyone met, by deadlines and scoreboards and unwritten rules. The endings were not. The endings were chosen — one conversation at a time, usually one conversation earlier than anyone wanted to have it.

Choose earlier. It is nearly always the whole trick.



APPENDIX A

Run This Exercise with Your Own Team

EVERYTHING IN THIS BOOK CAME from a simple exercise you can run yourself — with a project team, a leadership group, or a classroom. It takes one session plus preparation, and it reliably produces the most honest conversation a team has had in years. Here is the recipe.

Step 1 — Collect stories, anonymously. Ask each person to write a real conflict they experienced at work (or beyond it, if they choose). Give a structure: the background and the people involved; what triggered it; how each side actually responded; how it ended, or where it stands. Insist on anonymity — no names, including their own, and no identifying details. Anonymity is the entire engine of this exercise; it is what buys honesty. Use an anonymous form, and set a minimum length (three hundred words or so) to push past one-line summaries.

Step 2 — Swap and analyse. Redistribute the stories at random, making sure nobody receives their own. Each person analyses the story they receive against five questions: What was the root cause — not the surface event, but the mechanism underneath? Who were the stakeholders, and what did each stand to lose — including people not named in the story? Which conflict-handling mode was actually used (competing, collaborating, compromising, avoiding, accommodating)? Which mode would have fitted better, and why — with "collaborating" banned unless they can show interests overlapped, both sides were willing, and time existed? And what practices would have prevented the conflict, or caught it early — named concretely, not as "better communication."

Step 3 — Harvest the patterns together. In the group session, don't discuss individual stories — protect the anonymity. Discuss the aggregate: What triggered most of our conflicts? How many endings were "task done, relationship damaged"? What did we all prescribe? (Watch the collaboration reflex appear in your own numbers — then discuss why.) Which prevention ideas came up three times or more? Those recurring ideas are your team's own playbook, written by your team; adopt two of them on the spot.

A few cautions from experience. Read everything before the session, and prepare for the possibility that a story describes something serious — a policy violation, harassment, a legal issue — which deserves a private channel, not a workshop. Never let anyone speculate aloud about a story's author. And run the exercise on yourself first: write your own worst conflict, honestly, before asking anyone else to. You will discover it is harder, and more useful, than it looks.



APPENDIX B

The Five Modes on One Page

COMPETING — I WIN, YOU LOSE. High assertiveness, low cooperation. Right when: an emergency needs a decision now; a rule, safety issue or fact is at the centre; you hold real evidence and holding the line is your job. Costs: relationship capital, every time; information, if it ends the conversation too early. Watch for: winning the issue and losing the person; "it was never the same again."

Collaborating — we both win. High assertiveness, high cooperation. Right when: stakes are high for both sides, interests genuinely overlap, both parties are willing, and there is time. Costs: time and honesty; exposure of real interests. Watch for: prescribing it where its conditions don't exist — no overlap, no willingness, no time. It is the best mode and the worst default.

Compromising — we each give some. Medium on both axes. Right when: power is roughly equal, the clock is loud, and the relationship is worth more than the gap between "fair" and "half." Costs: the underlying question stays unanswered and may return. Watch for: splitting the difference on facts or rules — a fact meets in the middle only by becoming half wrong.

Avoiding — nobody engages. Low on both axes. Right when: the issue is trivial, or emotions need a cooling-off period before the real conversation. Costs: compounds silently; problems grow in the dark. Watch for: avoidance without a return date. "Not now, but Thursday" is strategy; "not now" forever is a slow goodbye.

Accommodating — you win, I yield. Low assertiveness, high cooperation. Right when: you realise you are wrong, or the relationship genuinely matters more than the issue. Costs: unpaid emotional bills if you yield on things that matter to you; a reputation as someone who always folds. Watch for: yielding under threat and calling it harmony.

And the two questions that outrank every mode: Is the task truly sorted? Would these people willingly work together again? "Resolved" means both.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

YASAS SRI WICKRAMASINGHE, PhD, teaches project management to postgraduate students — most of them working professionals — and has spent years helping teams navigate the collisions this book describes. His classes are built on a simple conviction: that real stories, honestly told, teach more about managing people and projects than any framework alone. This is his first book for a general audience. The forty-five conflicts in it are real; the names are not.